Measuring Narrative Latency in Taiwan

THE CORE CHALLENGE

The Gap Between Rumor and Reality

Narrative latency is the critical window during which a rumor circulates unchallenged.

As response speeds slow, the **"Response Window"** widens, allowing misinformation to take root before fact-checkers can intervene.

PEAK MANIPULATION YEAR

2024

Taiwan Election Cycle

A high-intensity environment where fast response speed was most critical.

Cofacts Response Performance

Fact-checking response time significantly degraded between presidential election cycles.

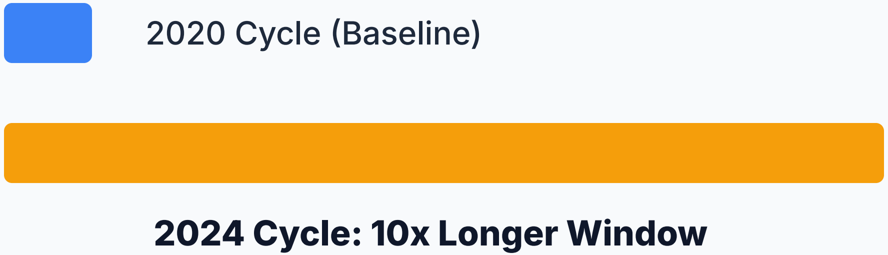
CRITICAL PERFORMANCE GAP

10x

Slower Response

Increase in median latency between the 2020 and 2024 election cycles.

VISUALIZING THE RESPONSE WINDOW



The "Response Window" has significantly widened, allowing rumors to circulate freely for much longer periods before intervention.

The slowdown isn't an overload story

10× slower — despite 62% LESS volume

SUBMISSION VOLUME

2020 CYCLE

5,798

32 submissions / day

2024 CYCLE

2,191

12 submissions / day

62% DROP

REPLY LATENCY CLIMB

6.7h →

67.2h

Volume can't explain the slowdown. Article complexity didn't shift meaningfully.

CRITICAL TAKEAWAY

Cofacts isn't drowning — it's shrinking on both sides.

Fewer submitters, slower repliers.

The intervention question isn't "more volunteers."

"Why did 60% of the submission base leave?"

Data: Cofacts HF snapshot 2026-05-10 | Election Window: ±90 days around polling

Defining Narrative Latency

The Concept

Latency = The Response Window

While a rumor remains unchallenged, it circulates freely. This window represents the critical time for intervention.

The Metric

Shifting from Artifacts to Time

Traditional disinformation analysis usually counts ***artifacts***. This specific study pivots to count ***time*** as the primary unit of measure.

The Context

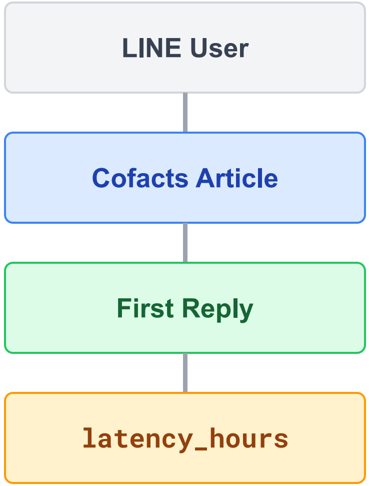
2024: Taiwan's Peak Manipulation

According to Doublethink Lab's ***Artificial Multiverse*, 2024 was a peak year for foreign information manipulation.**

Fast response mattered most in this high-intensity environment.

Methodology: Measuring Narrative Latency

Data Pipeline



`latency = reply_time - article_time`

Dataset Filters

- **Source:** Cofacts HF snapshot 2026-05-10
- **Sample:** 68,533 article-reply pairs (2016–2026)
- **Election Window:** ±90 days around polling
- **Filters:** Status = NORMAL; Type = TEXT

Drop Rate

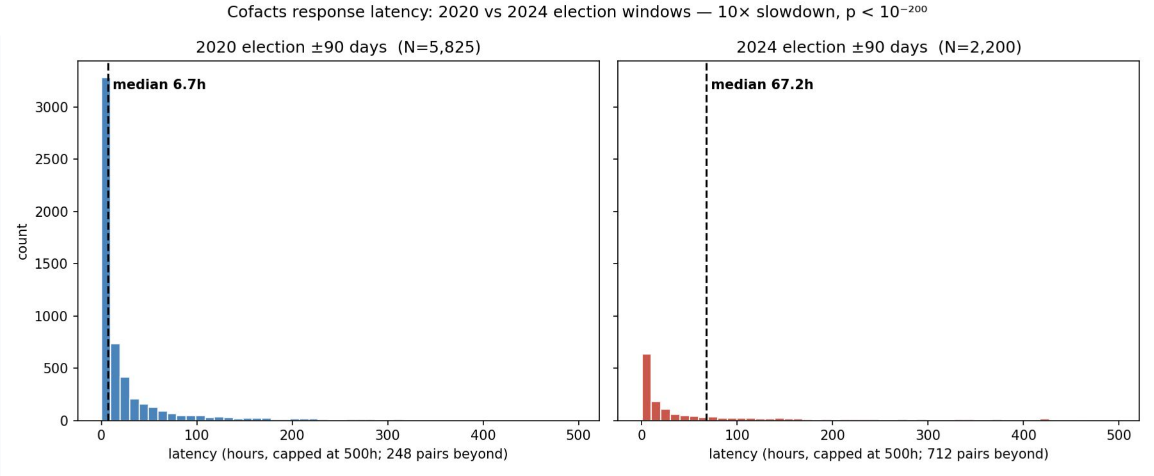
16.9%

Reported transparently

Stat Test

Mann–Whitney U
One-sided distribution analysis of response speeds

Key Finding: 10× Slowdown Between Election Cycles



Robust to survivorship — ratio unchanged when restricted to articles ≥6 months pre-snapshot

ELECTION WINDOW

10.7h

pooled 2016 + 2020 + 2024

BASELINE OVERALL

24.0h

The 2024 slowdown occurred **despite** intense election mobilization, which actually drives response speeds to be faster than the baseline.

Caveat: measures Cofacts community response speed only. Cofacts is the only place in Taiwan with reliable rumor-reply timestamps.

Recommendations: Updated for the Bilateral-Decline Finding

The volume paradox changes what Cofacts should do next

Original (Throughput Fix)	Updated (Strategic Diagnostic)
Recruit more volunteers Focus on expanding the editor base to handle high volume.	**First diagnose user attrition** Why did 60% of submitters leave? Recruitment is secondary if the inflow is shrinking faster than the base.
Build triage tools Prioritize incoming rumors for faster processing.	**Solve the audience-attrition problem** Survey former active contributors — why did they stop?
Pre-position rebuttals Prepare responses for predictable seasonal rumors.	**Distribution as the new bottleneck** Rebuttals only help if they reach exposed people. Shift focus from creation to dissemination.
Improve volunteer onboarding	**Secondary priority**

Securing the Information Front

Data-driven resilience against narrative manipulation
starts with radical transparency and community speed.